

Space Reclaimer

End-of-Care Digital Service & Interactive Home Equipment Guide

A calm, grief-aware digital service designed for former carers navigating the sudden end of a caring role. Space Reclaimer uses an interactive room-by-room SVG house floorplan to guide users through returning, donating, or recycling specialist medical equipment at their own pace.

Discipline

Service & UX Design

Context

CSM Service Brief

Tools

HTML/CSS/SVG, User Testing

Outcome

A working multi-room interactive web application tested with primary users, pairing spatial SVG room navigation with practical UK-specific NHS, council, and charity disposal guidance.

Scenario selection — life transitions



Fig. 01–04 — Initial scenario mapping exploring major human life transitions before selecting the end of a caring role

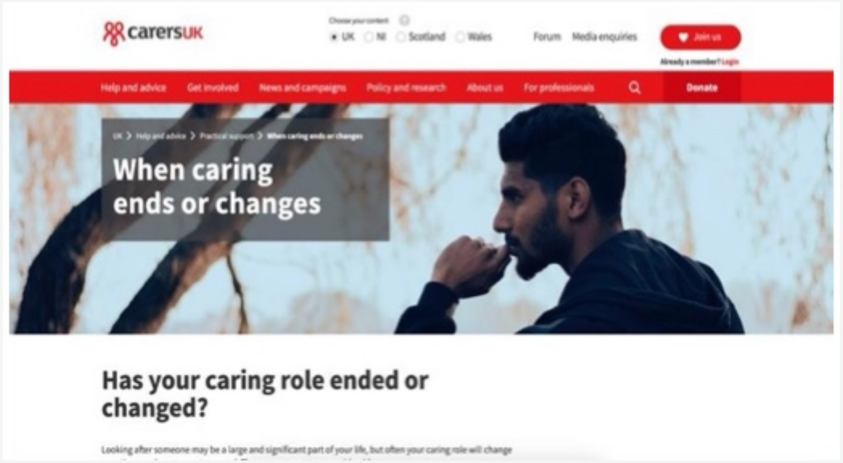
Selecting the Scenario: 'My Caring Role Is Over'

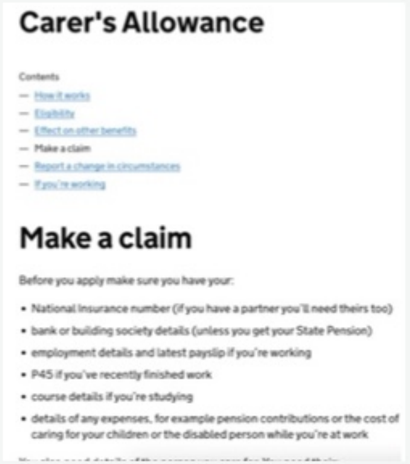
Tasked with designing a digital service supporting people through an underserved life transition, I evaluated multiple scenarios before focusing on the abrupt transition faced by unpaid family carers and live-in carers when the person they care for passes away or moves into residential care.

01 **Acute Administrative Overload** — Carers are immediately confronted with fragmented council, NHS, and legal tasks.

02 **Physical Reminders in Every Room** — Hospital beds, hoists, and commodes remain in the home with unclear return routes.

Secondary research — the post-caring void





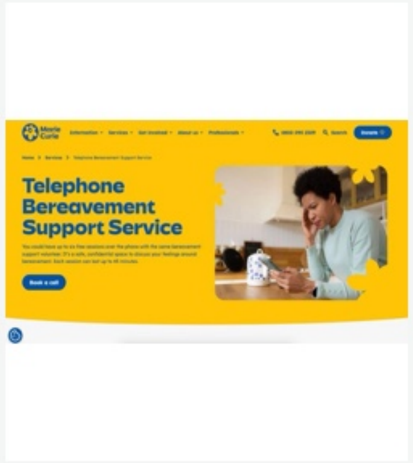


Fig. 05–07 — Secondary research across Carers UK, Marie Curie, and NHS equipment loan pathways

Fragmented Guidance & Equipment Confusion

Reviewing Carers UK, Marie Curie, and local NHS Trust guidance revealed a stark gap: while emotional bereavement support exists, practical instructions for clearing a home of mixed NHS-loaned, council-funded, and privately purchased care equipment are scattered across dozens of disconnected websites.

01 **NHS Community Equipment Loans** — Items bearing Medequip/NRS barcode stickers must be booked for collection, not thrown away.

02 **Charitable Donation Restrictions** — Charities like British Red Cross and Age UK accept certain mobility aids while rejecting mattresses or opened consumables.

03 **Specialist Disposal & Recycling** — Stairlifts, hoists, and prescription sharps/medications each require distinct pharmacy or council pathways.

Primary research — interviews with former carers





Two Distinct Post-Care Realities

Conducting semi-structured interviews with two former carers uncovered two very different sets of pressures:

01 **Carer 1 — Unrelated Live-In Carer** — Faced immediate 24–48 hour legal and housing vulnerability, needing an urgent checklist to document inventory, hand over keys, and protect against disputes with distant relatives.

02 **Carer 2 — Bereaved Family Carer** — Described an overwhelming emotional 'void' where walking into a bedroom or bathroom full of clinical machinery triggered grief, yet tackling the whole house at once felt impossible.

Fig. 08–09 — Primary interview synthesis comparing an unrelated live-in carer (Interviewee 1) and a family carer (Interviewee 2)

Scenario definition — during vs after caring

Mapping the Transition Across Five Life Dimensions

Synthesising secondary literature and primary carer interviews allowed me to map the exact structural shift that occurs when a caring role ends.

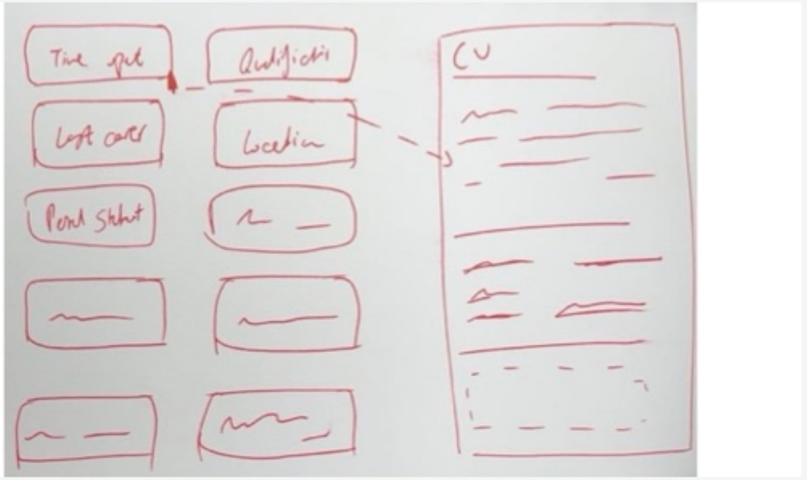
#	Life Dimension	During the Caring Role	After the Caring Role Ends (The Transition Void)
01	**Daily Routine**	Tightly structured around medication times, personal care, and mobility transfers	Sudden collapse of daily structure; disorienting hours of unallocated time
02	**Personal Identity**	Defined by protective responsibility, vigilance, and specialist knowledge	Abrupt loss of role and purpose: 'Who am I now that my caring role is over?'
03	**Social World**	Daily contact with district nurses, occupational therapists, and care workers	Professional care network withdraws almost overnight after death or admission
04	**Physical Home Space**	Rooms adapted into clinical zones: profiling beds, ceiling hoists, commodes	Home remains dominated by medical equipment with unclear return/disposal routes
05	**Support Systems**	Carer's Allowance, respite care, and active NHS equipment loan support	Fragmented bereavement admin across council, NHS, pharmacy, and charities

Service ideation — spatial vs linear models









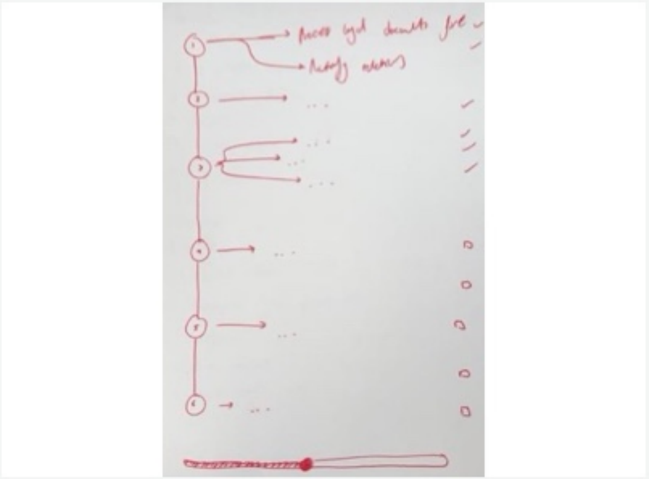


Fig. 10–14 — Early service wireframes exploring interactive room floorplans, progress trackers, and urgency-based admin checklists

Translating Carer Insights into Two

Because our two primary interviewees had contrasting needs —gentle spatial reclamation vs urgent legal/administrative protection—I developed two distinct functional web prototypes to test head-to-head with users.

01 **Direction A — Spatial Floorplan** — Breaks the home into calm, manageable rooms (Bedroom, Bathroom, Lounge, Kitchen).

02 **Direction B — Paced Checklist** — Prioritises time-critical 24h, 7-day, and 30-day administrative actions.

Prototype 1 — Space Reclaimer (spatial floorplan)

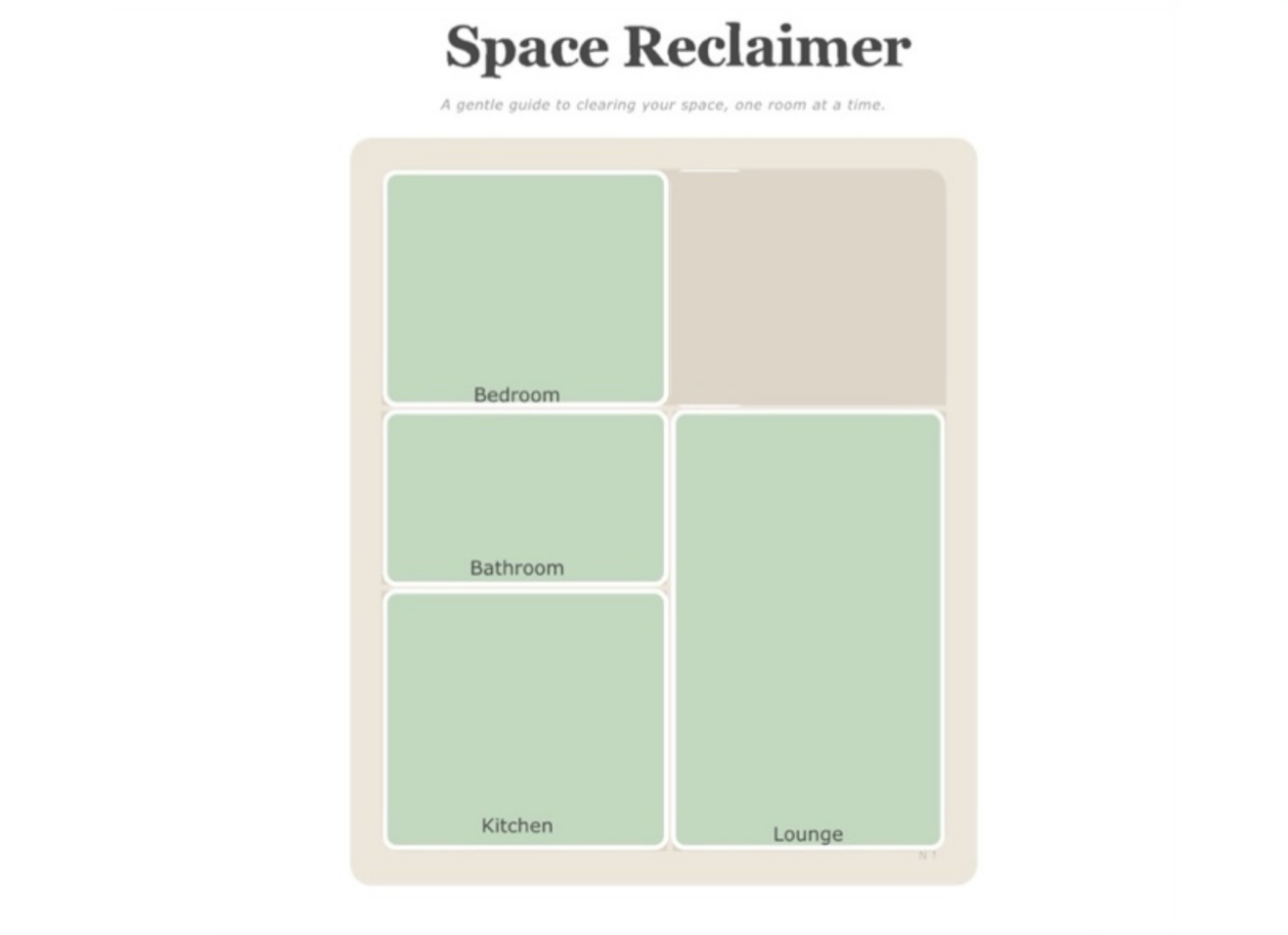


Fig. 15 — Prototype 1 ('Space Reclaimer'): interactive 4-room house floorplan with per-room progress bars and equipment disposal guides

Accompanying Rather Than Instructing

Prototype 1 uses an interactive SVG floorplan of a house as its primary navigation. Instead of confronting a bereaved carer with a long bureaucratic list, users simply click the room they feel ready to tackle today.

01 **Visual Room Selection** — Clicking Bedroom, Bathroom, Kitchen, or Lounge opens only the equipment typically found in that space.

02 **Three-Route UK Guidance** — Every item lists clear instructions for (1) NHS Loan Return, (2) Charity Donation, or (3) Council/Pharmacy Disposal.

03 **Gentle Progress Feedback** — Ticking off cleared items gradually fills the room's progress bar, visually reclaiming the home step by step.

Prototype 2 — The Paced Administrator (linear checklist)

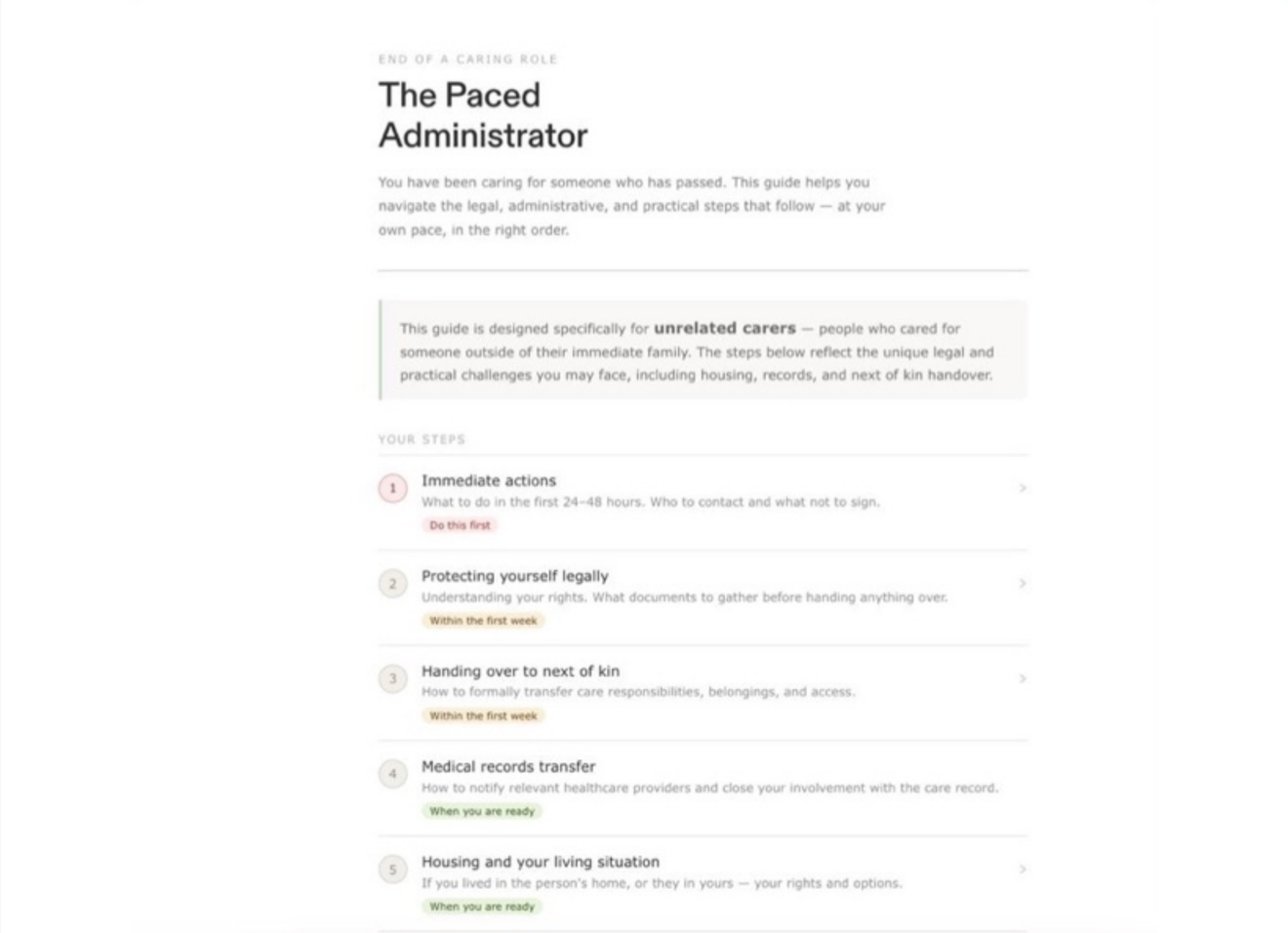


Fig. 16 — Prototype 2 ('The Paced Administrator'): six-stage linear checklist with Red / Amber / Green urgency badges

Structured Protection for Unrelated & Live-In Carers

Prototype 2 was designed around Interviewee 1's experience: a chronological, six-stage administrative checklist that shields live-in carers from legal exposure when a care placement ends abruptly.

01 **Immediate 24–48hr Safeguarding** — Red-badge tasks cover photographing room states, logging keys, and securing controlled medications.

02 **Structured Handover Protocol** — Amber-badge tasks guide formal communication with next-of-kin, care agencies, and landlords.

03 **Role Closure & Next Steps** — Green-badge tasks cover final pay reconciliation, references, and council tax exemptions.

Comparative user testing — Prototype 1 vs Prototype 2



Fig. 17–20 — Live user testing sessions comparing Prototype 1 (Space Reclaimer) and Prototype 2 (The Paced Administrator)

Round 1 Testing Feedback

Testing both live prototypes side-by-side with three participants produced unanimous preference for Prototype 1's spatial house metaphor while surfacing specific usability refinements:

01 **Tester 1 — Spatial Clarity** — Immediately understood the floorplan navigation, but asked whether ticking an item meant 'I have this item' or 'I have cleared this item'.

02 **Tester 2 — Emotional Tone** — Described Space Reclaimer as 'calm and non-overwhelming', whereas Prototype 2's red urgency badges felt stressful.

03 **Tester 3 — Real-World Utility** — Confirmed the NHS barcode return and charity rules were spot-on, and suggested adding a Staircase area for stairlifts.

Prototype evaluation & selection rationale

Criterion	Prototype 1: Space Reclaimer (Chosen)	Prototype 2: The Paced Administrator
Primary Metaphor	**Interactive room-by-room SVG house floorplan**	Chronological 6-stage administrative checklist
Emotional Tone	**Warm, grief-aware, self-paced ('accompanies rather than instructs')**	Urgent, procedural, compliance-focused (Red/Amber/Green badges)
Cognitive Load	**Low — visual spatial chunking hides irrelevant equipment**	High — presents dense text lists on the initial landing screen
User Testing Verdict	**Preferred by 3/3 testers as calm, distinctive, and immediately useful**	Seen as useful for agency staff but emotionally heavy for bereaved families
Differentiation	**Unique spatial tool; nothing comparable exists on UK charity sites**	Overlaps with existing government 'Tell Us Once' bereavement checklists

Why I Chose to Take 'Space Reclaimer' Forward

While Prototype 2 solved a niche agency-carer handover problem, Prototype 1 ('Space Reclaimer') addressed a universal, emotionally charged pain point—transforming a house full of clinical machinery back into a home through a calm, visual interface.

User journey map — iterative flow development

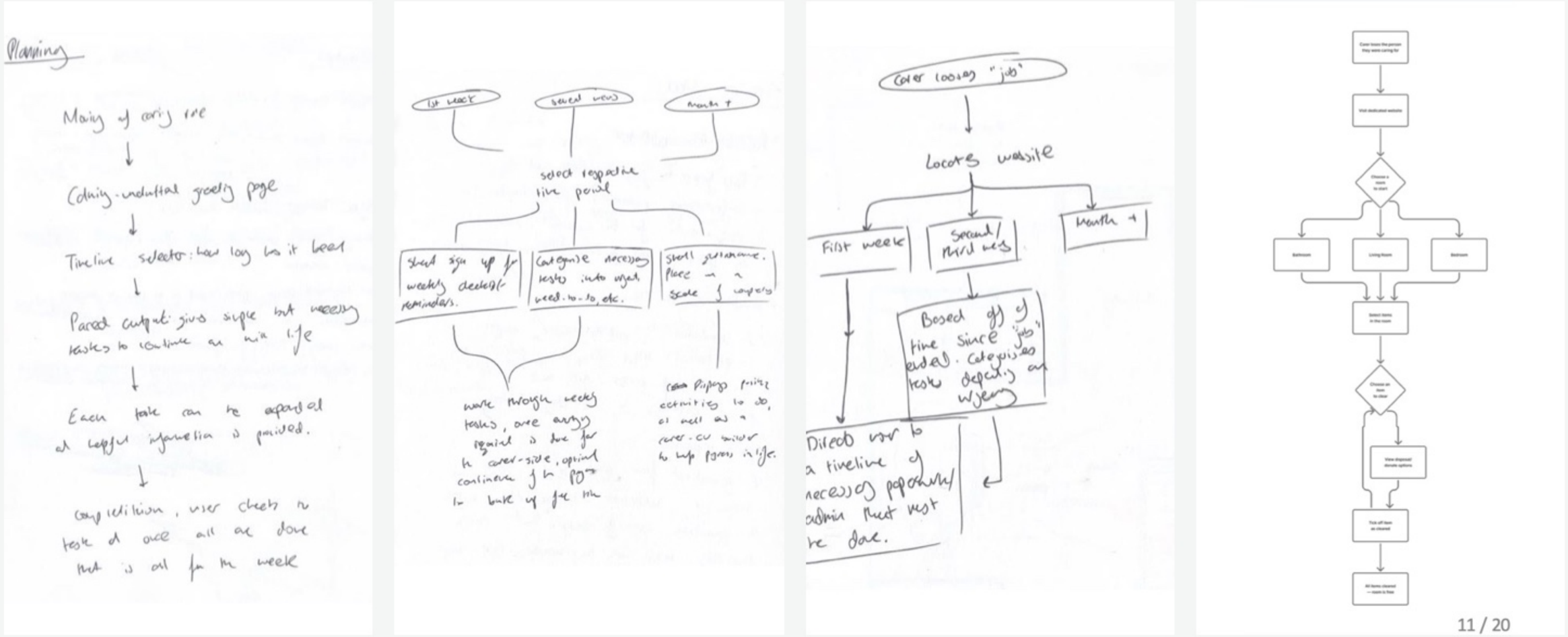
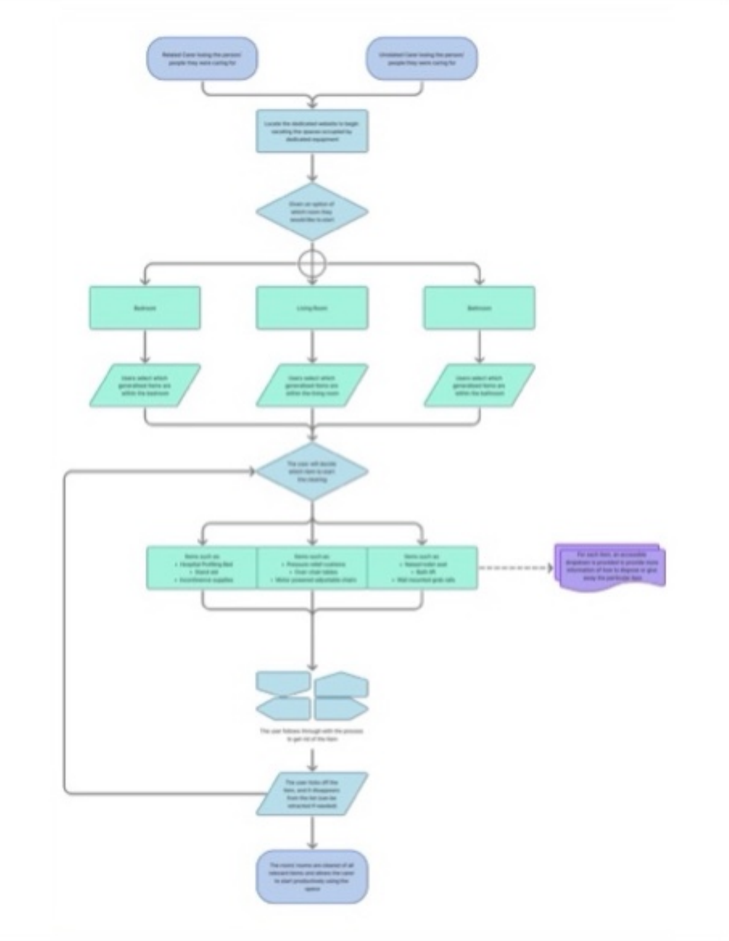
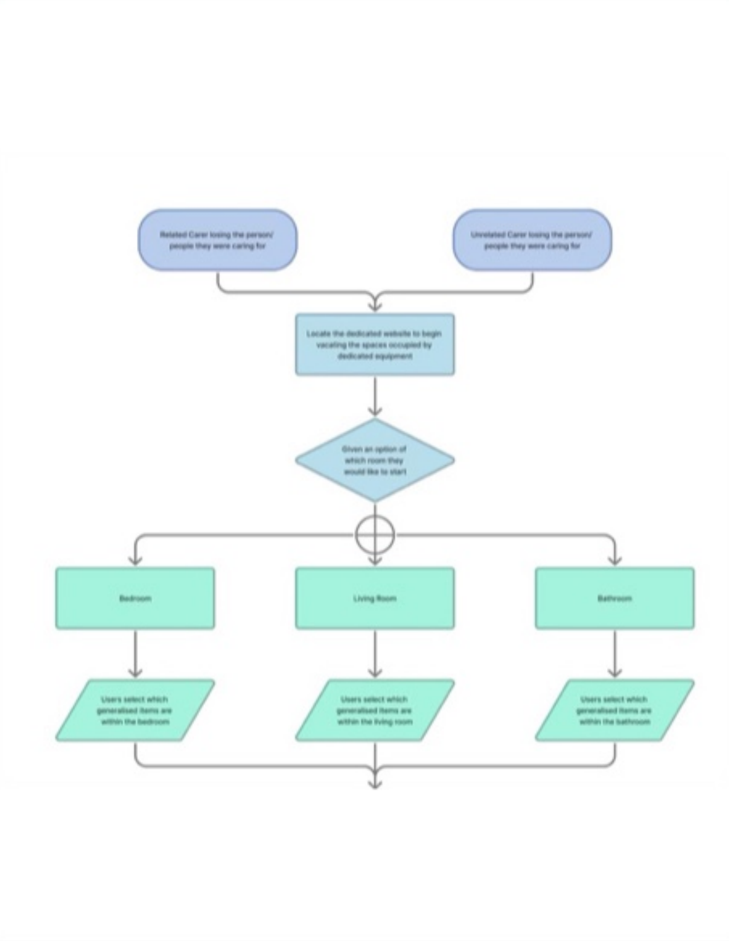


Fig. 21–24 — Iterative notebook flowcharts mapping entry points, room selection, item accordion expansion, and completion states

User journey map — full service architecture





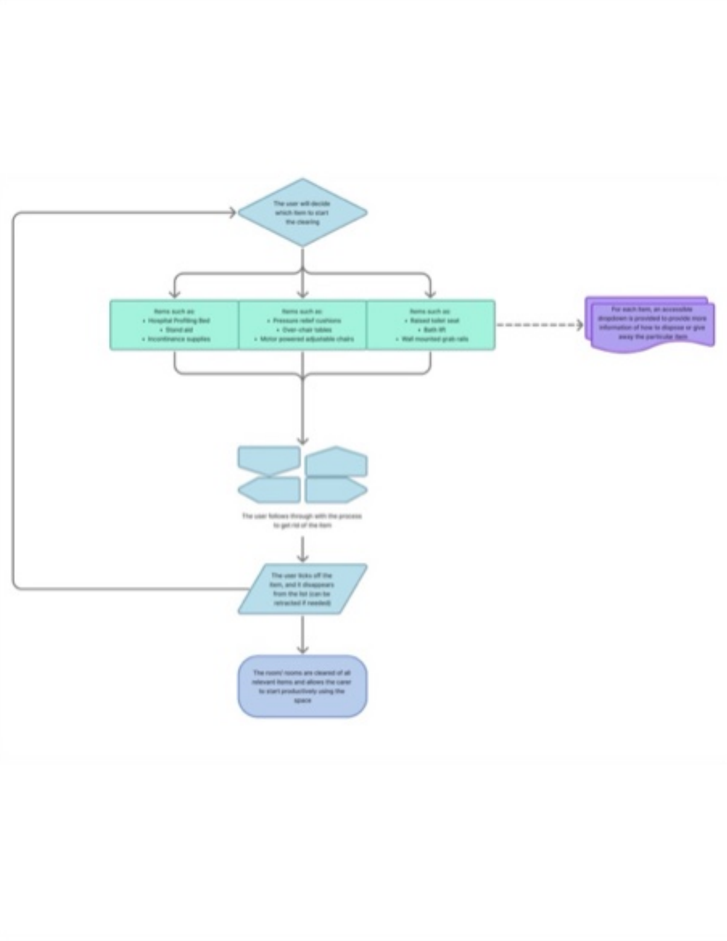


Fig. 25–27 — Complete end-to-end service blueprint: (1) Trigger & Landing -> (2) 5-Room SVG Navigation -> (3) Actionable UK Return/Donation Pathways

Iteration reflection — post-testing improvements

Translating Round 1 Critique into Concrete UI Upgrades

Before building the final multi-page web application, I audited every piece of friction observed during Round 1 user testing and defined four structural upgrades:

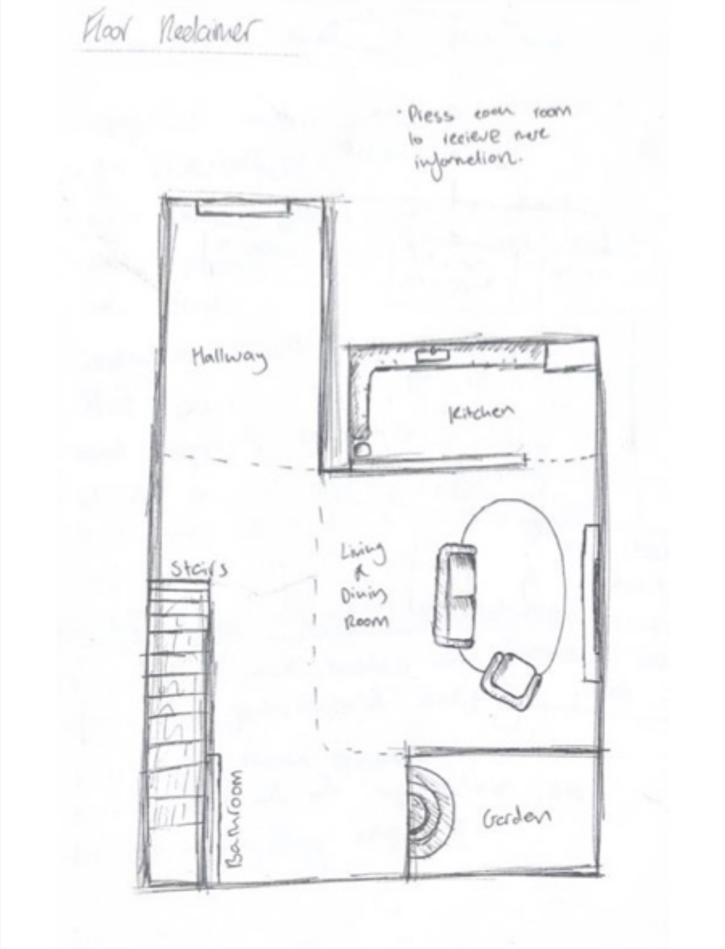
01 **Clarified the Two-Step Tick Mechanic** — Tester 1 was unsure what ticking an item meant. I rewrote the room header instructions to explicitly state: 'Select the items present in this room, then tick each one off as you clear it.'

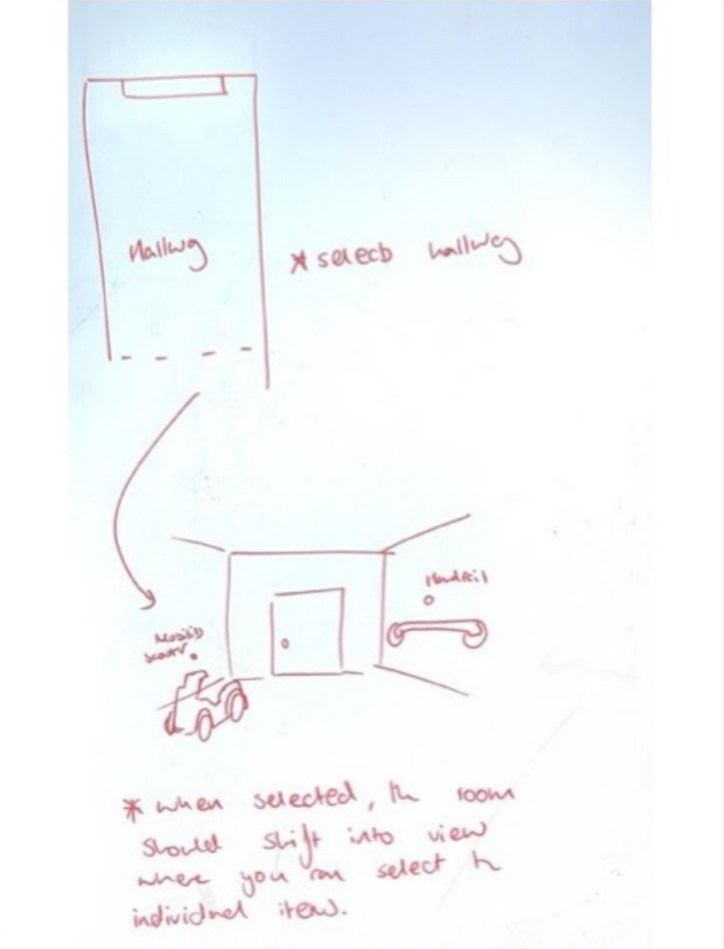
02 **Illustrated Recognisable Room Furniture SVGs** — Upgraded the abstract rectangular floorplan boxes into detailed architectural SVG rooms with recognisable beds, sofas, bathtubs, kitchen counters, and stairs.

03 **Expanded from 4 Rooms to 5 (Added Staircase)** — Directly acted on Tester 3's feedback by adding a dedicated 'Stairs / Hallway' zone covering stairlifts, banister grab rails, and threshold ramps.

04 **Separated Dedicated Room Views** — Moved from a single crowded page to dedicated room views so users only see one calm room checklist at a time, with persistent back-to-floorplan navigation.

Final website planning — 5-room floorplan & hierarchy





Spatial Information Architecture

Each room on the homepage SVG acts as an interactive portal linking to its own dedicated room checklist page, while keeping overall home progress gentle and non-intrusive.

01 **Bedroom (6 Items)** — Profiling bed, pressure mattress, hoist, commode, overbed table, bed rails.

02 **Bathroom (5 Items)** — Bath lift, shower chair, raised toilet seat, grab rails, non-slip mat.

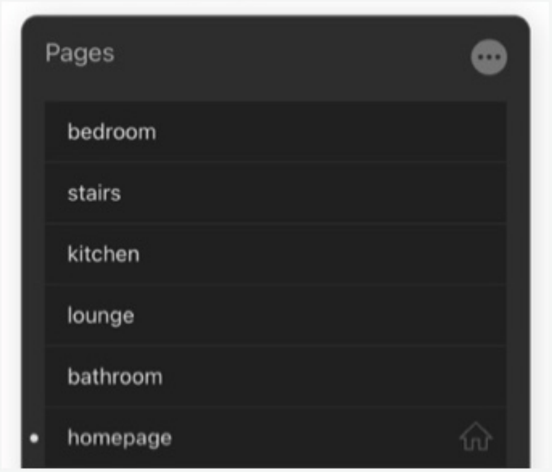
03 **Lounge (5 Items)** — Riser-recliner armchair, walking frame, rollator, wheelchair, cushion.

04 **Kitchen & Stairs (9 Items)** — Perching stool, adaptive cutlery, medication dosette, stairlift, ramps.

Fig. 28–29 — Detailed architectural floorplan sketch with furniture icons and multi-page site map

Website development & grief-aware colour system







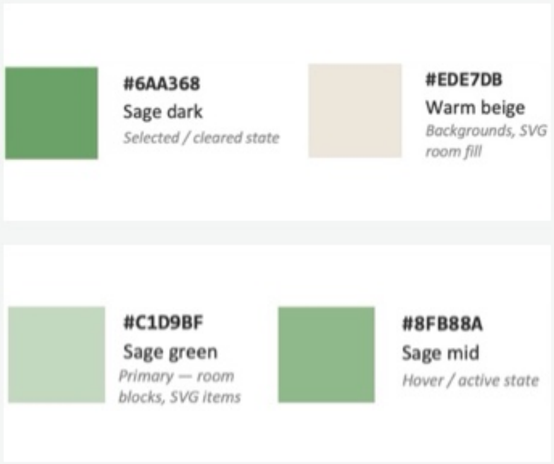


Fig. 30–34 — Cargo page hierarchy (Homepage + 5 Room pages), item disposal cards, and calming Sage Green / Warm Beige palette

Grief-Aware Visual Identity

Clinical NHS blues and harsh warning reds were deliberately avoided. Instead, Space Reclaimer pairs warm domestic paper tones (#EDE7DB) with restorative sage greens (#6AA368 and #C1D9BF)—evoking calm domestic renewal.

01 **#EDE7DB — Warm Linen Background** — Softens screen glare and feels like tactile stationery.

02 **#6AA368 — Restorative Sage Accent** — Signals completed rooms and interactive hover states calmly.

03 **#2C352E — Deep Forest Charcoal** — High-contrast, accessible typography for older carers.

Technical development — HTML, CSS & SVG architecture

BEFORE — static, broken

HTML:

```
<ul class="asset-list">
  <li>
    <strong>Hospital /
Profiling Bed</strong>
    &amp;nbsp;&amp;nbsp;Adjustable
electric bed for
    positioning, comfort, and
safe
    transfers.&amp;nbsp;&amp;nbsp;
  </li>
  <li>
    <strong>Stand Aid</strong>
    &amp;nbsp;&amp;nbsp;Mechanical
transfer aid to
    support safe
standing.&amp;nbsp;&amp;nbsp;
  </li>
</ul>
```

CSS:

```
.asset-group {
  cursor: default;
}
.asset-box {
  fill: #C1D9BF;
  stroke: #FFFFFF;
  stroke-width: 4px;
}
.asset-label {
  font-family: 'Verdana';
  font-size: 11px;
  fill: #4A4A4A;
  text-anchor: middle;
}
.asset-list li {
  background: #F5F0E8;
  border-left: 4px solid
#C1D9BF;
  padding: 10px 14px;
  font-size: 14px;
}
```

AFTER — interactive, working

HTML:

```
<ul id="sr-list">
  <li class="sr-item" data-
index="0">
    <div class="sr-
cb"></div>
    <div class="sr-it">
      <span class="sr-
in">Hospital / Profiling
Bed</span>
      <span class="sr-
id">Adjustable electric bed
for
      positioning, comfort,
and safe transfers.</span>
      <button class="sr-db"

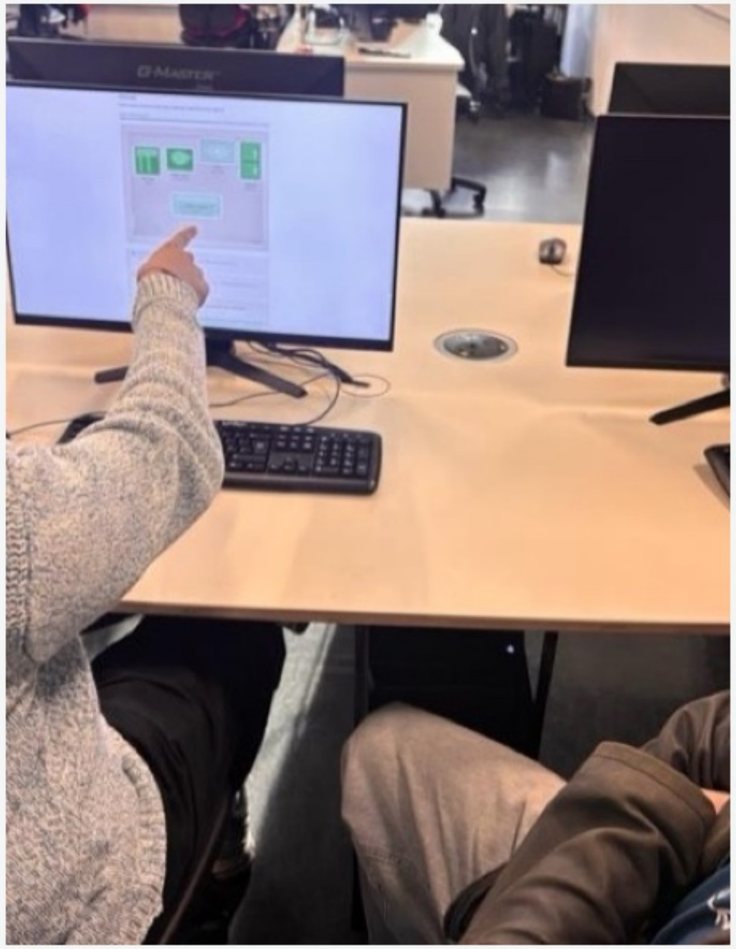
onclick="srToggle(this,event
)">
        How to dispose ▾
      </button>
    </div>
```

CSS:

```
#sr-list {
  list-style: none;
  padding: 0;
  margin-top: 24px;
}
.sr-item {
  background: #F5F0E8;
  border-left: 4px solid
#C1D9BF;
  border-radius: 0 6px 6px 0;
  padding: 10px 14px;
  display: flex;
  align-items: flex-start;
  gap: 12px;
  cursor: pointer;
}
.sr-item.sr-done {
  opacity: 0.5;
  border-left-color: #8FB88A;
}
.sr-cb
```

Fig. 35 — Code evolution: refactoring static Prototype 1 markup into modular, interactive HTML/CSS/SVG room templates with live progress calculation

Final user testing — live website verification



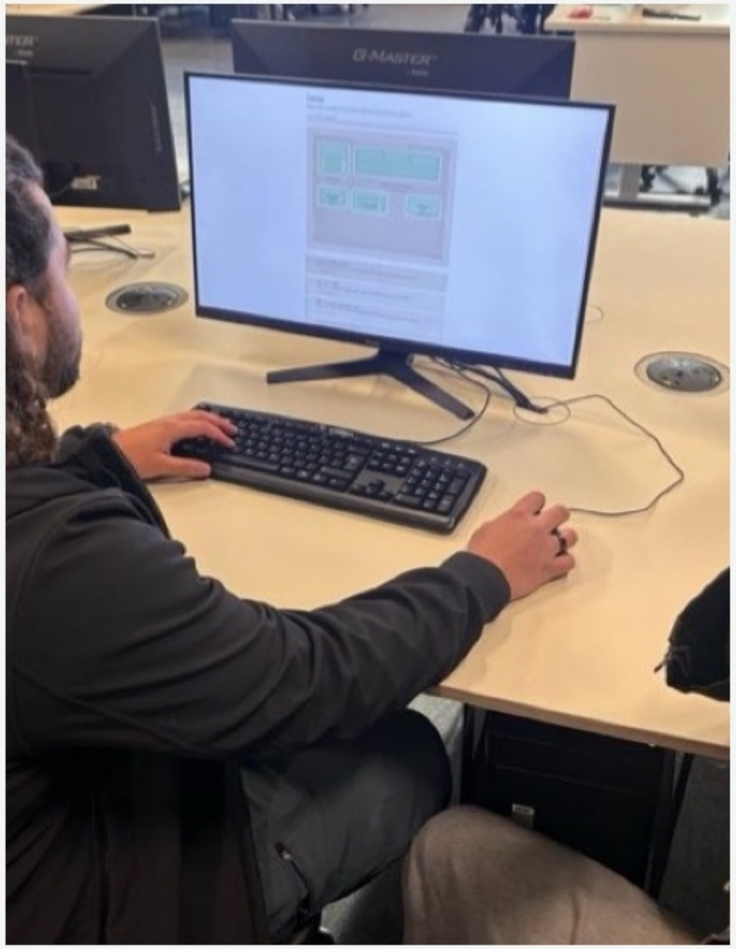


Fig. 36–37 — Final verification sessions testing the completed 5-room web application on laptop and desktop

Round 2 Verification Outcomes

Testing the finished multi-page website confirmed that every ambiguity from Round 1 had been resolved:

01 **Tester 1 — Effortless Spatial Flow** — Navigated the 5-room SVG floorplan immediately and praised the clear dropdown disposal instructions even without prior caring experience.

02 **Tester 2 — Calming Tone & Palette** — Highlighted the soothing sage-and-beige palette and noted that breaking the house into individual rooms eliminated feeling overwhelmed.

03 **Next Deployment Step** — Testers suggested linking postcode lookup directly to local council Medequip/NRS collection booking forms.

Final website — interactive room & checklist views



Fig. 38–41 — Live room screens: Living Room SVG & checklist, Kitchen SVG & checklist, and expanded NHS / charity / council disposal accordions

Final reflection — what Space Reclaimer achieves

Designing for Emotional & Practical Recovery

Space Reclaimer demonstrates how service design can support people at their most vulnerable—not through intrusive notifications or bureaucratic checklists, but by translating an overwhelming domestic transition into a calm, spatial, room-by-room guide.

Critical Reflection & Future Scope

Building two competing prototypes early and testing them honestly with primary users was the turning point of the project. In a full national rollout with Carers UK or Marie Curie, Space Reclaimer would integrate a postcode API to auto-populate local NHS equipment provider phone numbers (Medequip, NRS Healthcare, Millbrook) and local hospice furniture collection links.

01 **5 Interactive SVG Rooms** — Bedroom, Bathroom, Living Room, Kitchen, and Staircase/Hallway.

02 **25 Specialist Care Equipment Guides** — Detailed UK return, donation, and recycling pathways for every major care item.

03 **Zero-Pressure Self-Pacing** — No deadlines or red warning badges—users reclaim their space one room at a time.

04 **Validated with Primary Users** — Two rounds of live testing shaped the floorplan graphics, copywriting, and architecture.